UX/UI CASE STUDY

# Bondly

## New people. Real plans.

A mobile app for small-group meetups that can turn into ongoing groups. Researched, designed and tested from scratch.

Agostina Boris · Research, product concept and UX/UI design · 2026

Try the prototype →



CONTEXT · THE PROBLEM

# Wanting to meet new people isn't the same as meeting them

### WHERE IT STARTED

In the meetup groups I'm part of, the same people kept going to the same places. I wanted to find out whether that was a real gap or just my own experience.

### RESEARCH QUESTION

**When do existing groups and tools help people meet someone new, and when do they fall short?**

CONTEXT · GOAL AND ROLE

# From a first meetup to an ongoing group

### My role

Solo project: UX research, product concept, UX/UI design, prototyping and usability testing.

### Scope

Discover a meetup, join a small group, show up, and plan the next meetup together.

### Evidence

7 interviews and 2 venue conversations. A clickable prototype tested with 5 people: 4 completed the full journey.

RESEARCH · INTERVIEWS

# I interviewed 7 people and 2 venues

| | Who | Age | City |
|---|---|---|---|
| P01 | Freelancer with an irregular social life | 29 | Buenos Aires |
| P02 | Analyst with a stable but closed circle | 34 | Córdoba |
| P03 | Student looking for creative spaces | 24 | Rosario |
| P04 | Parent and business owner with little time | 41 | Montevideo |
| P05 | Signs up, but doesn't always show | 27 | Buenos Aires |
| P06 | Retiree looking for activity and company | 63 | La Plata |
| P07 | Recently moved, no local network | 31 | Mendoza |

**METHOD**

Semi-structured interviews about real past experiences, not opinions about a future app.

Venues: a cultural center and an outdoor activity space.

Exploratory and qualitative: not representative of all users.

Research in Argentina and Uruguay. The prototype is set in Barcelona because [reason]; a pilot would need local validation.

RESEARCH · HOW PEOPLE DO IT TODAY

# Finding company takes several tools



**Discover**

Instagram and local searches



**Join**

Meetup and Strava



**Coordinate**

WhatsApp and Facebook groups



**Places**

Cultural centers, university, retiree clubs

**Close circles bring trust, but fewer chances to meet someone new.**

RESEARCH · BENCHMARK

# How others bring people together

| | Meetup | Bumble BFF | Timeleft | Bondly |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Starting point | Interest communities and events | Nearby profiles and groups | Organized meetups and an affinity quiz | Interests and small meetups nearby |
| Who organizes | User picks the event; a host runs it | User picks connections; groups make plans | User books; the platform assigns the group | User picks the plan; Bondly organizes and forms a small group |
| Lesson for Bondly | Give a concrete reason to meet | Support continuity inside the group | Remove the effort of organizing | Combine the three, and invite the same group to meet again |

OPPORTUNITY · HYPOTHESIS

## Choose a plan, know what to expect, and keep the connection after.

Official sources reviewed Oct 14, 2026. Desk research, not usability testing.

RESEARCH · FINDINGS

# Three moments where people drop off

### 1 · BEFORE GOING

Doubts about the plan, tiredness, weather or fear of arriving alone can undo a sign-up.

*"[Quote from P05]"*

[N] of 7 participants, incl. P05 and P02

**Opportunity**

**Make the plan concrete and show it's happening.**

### 2 · ON ARRIVAL

Introductions and the first silences were the hardest part. A shared activity helps.

*"[Quote from P0_]"*

[N] of 7 participants

**Opportunity**

**Say exactly where to wait and who's already there.**

### 3 · AFTER THE MEETUP

Contacts fade when nobody proposes the next plan. A set date, place and group chat kept it going.

*"[Quote from P0_]"*

[N] of 7 participants

**Opportunity**

**Make suggesting a date and place the easy next step.**

RESEARCH · VENUES

# Hosting a group takes more than a space

| | Cultural center | Outdoor space |
|---|---|---|
| Group size | 8 to 25 people | Varies by activity |
| Notice | 5 days | 3 to 4 days |
| Expect organizers to handle | Sign-ups and the list | Safety, first aid, being there |
| Main friction | Late confirmations, disorder | Overbooking, absent organizer |

HOW BONDLY ANSWERS IT

**Late confirmations** → a meetup is confirmed once three members join.

**Absent organizer** → Bondly organizes every meetup and names the exact meeting point.

**Unclear expectations** → the app says upfront what isn't included.

RESEARCH · THE KEY INSIGHT

# Interest doesn't guarantee attendance. A good first meetup doesn't guarantee a second.

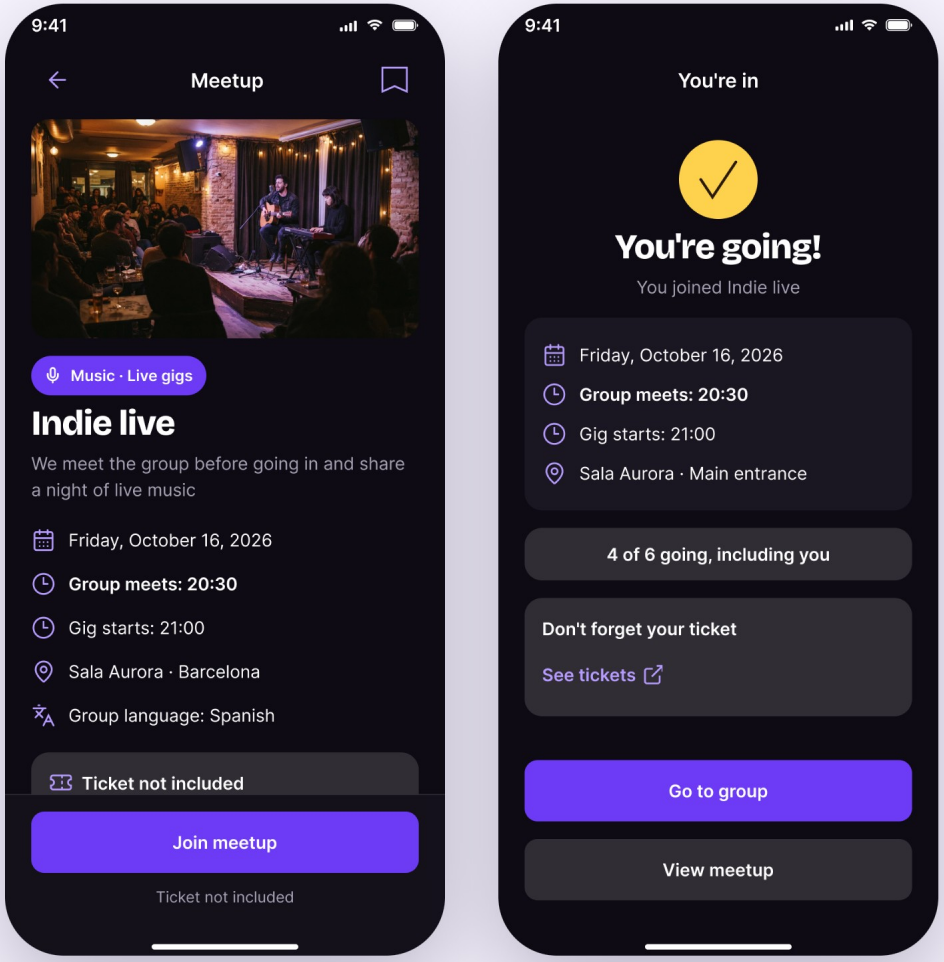
I started out designing for meeting someone new. The research moved the problem: the hard part is showing up, and then meeting again. So the design focuses on three moments: deciding to go, arriving, and planning the next meetup.

DESIGN · 1 · BEFORE GOING

# Make the plan feel certain

- Separate times for when the group meets and when the activity starts.
- The exact meeting point, down to the entrance.
- Who's going, the group's language, and what isn't included.

**From finding 1: doubts about the plan undo sign-ups**



DESIGN · 2 · ON ARRIVAL

# Nobody should have to look for strangers

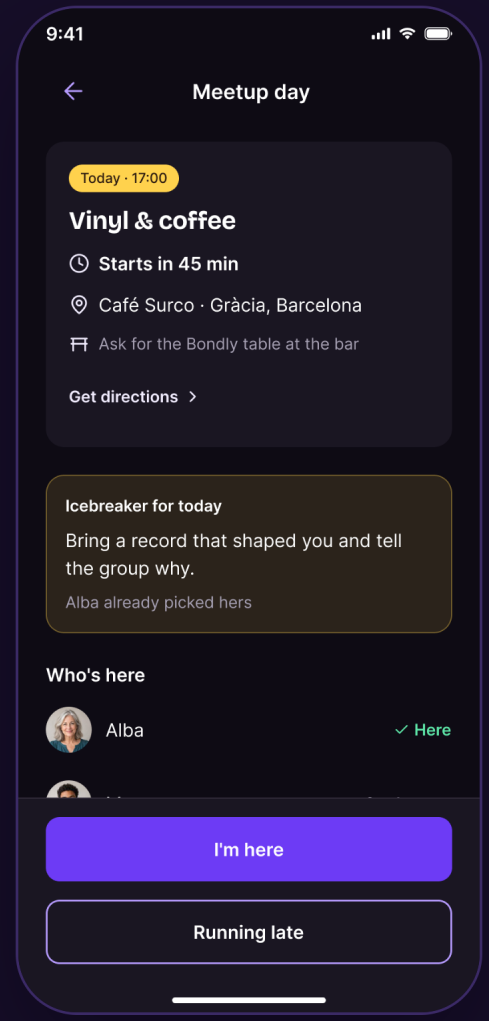
> A concrete instruction for where to go, like asking for the Bondly table at the bar.

> Who's already there, who's on the way and who's running late.

> One tap to say "I'm here" or "Running late".

> An icebreaker tied to the activity, so the first silence already has a topic.

**From finding 2: the first minutes are the hardest**

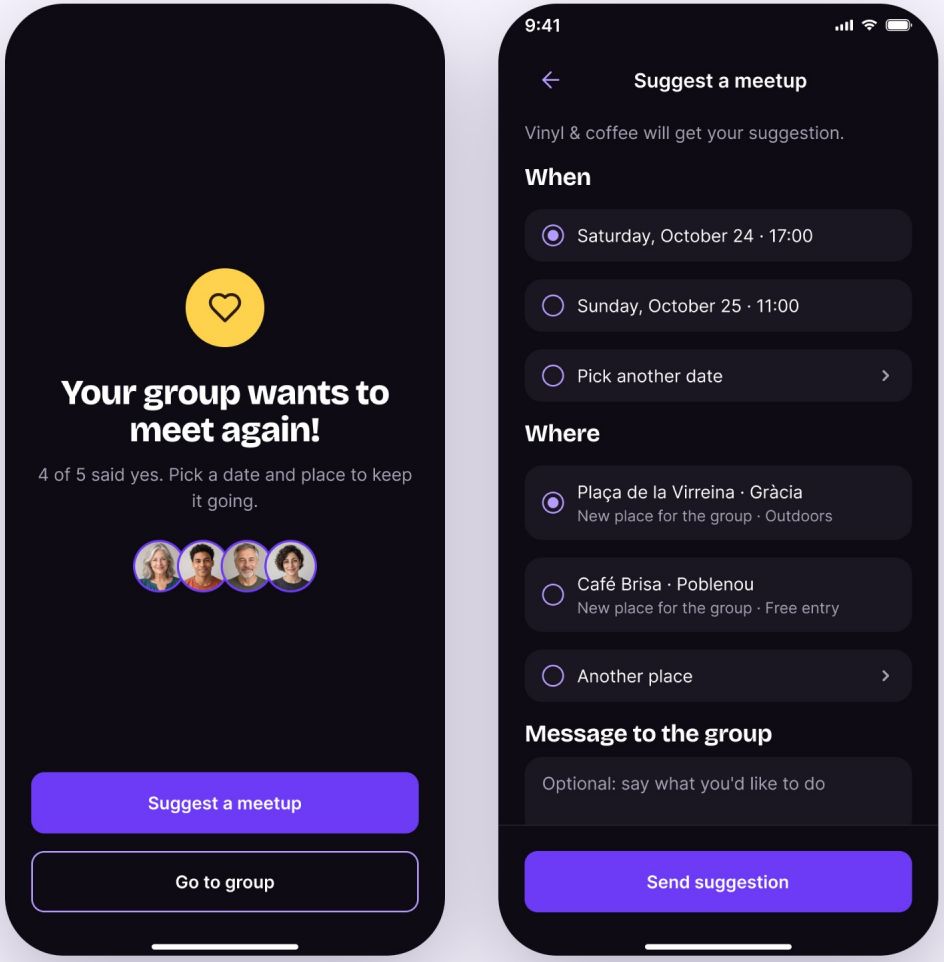


DESIGN · 3 · AFTER THE MEETUP

# Make meeting again the easy next step

- The app asks if the group wants to meet again.
- Anyone can suggest a date and place, with spots the group hasn't been to flagged.
- The meetup is confirmed once three members join.

From finding 3: contacts fade without a plan



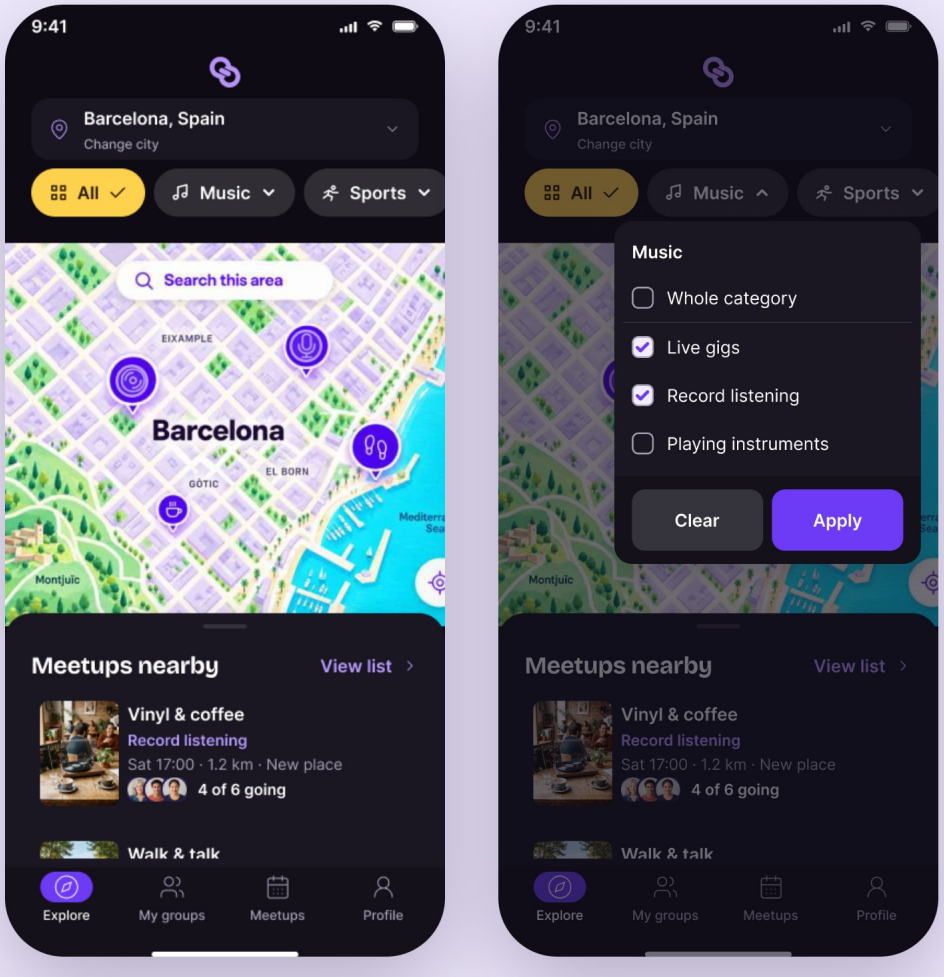
DESIGN · DISCOVERY

# Something you enjoy, somewhere new

A map with nearby meetups, each tagged when it's a new place, against "always the same places".

Each interest opens its subcategories, so people narrow down without leaving the map.

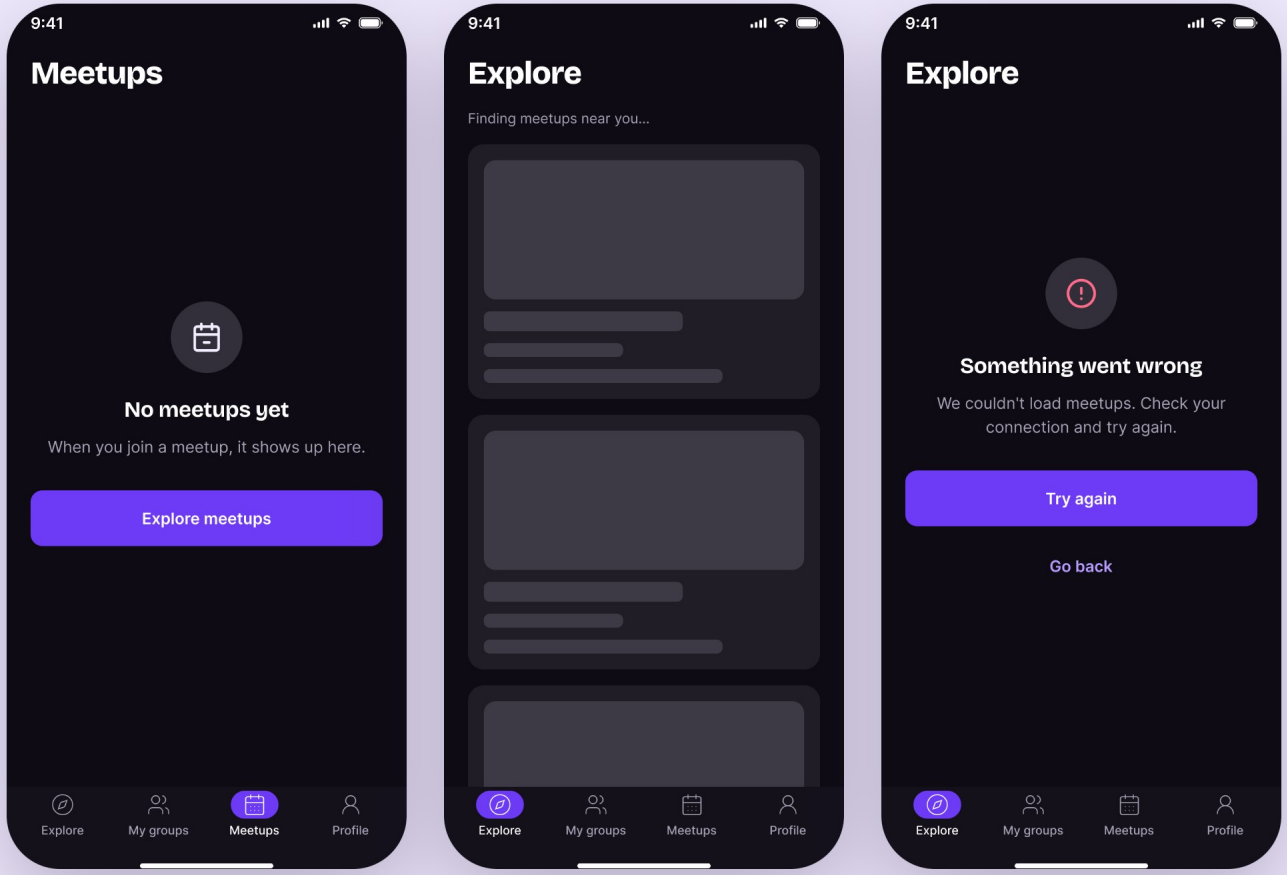
Every card shows how many people are going, so the plan looks alive before joining.



DESIGN · EDGE CASES

# Every screen knows what to say when it's empty

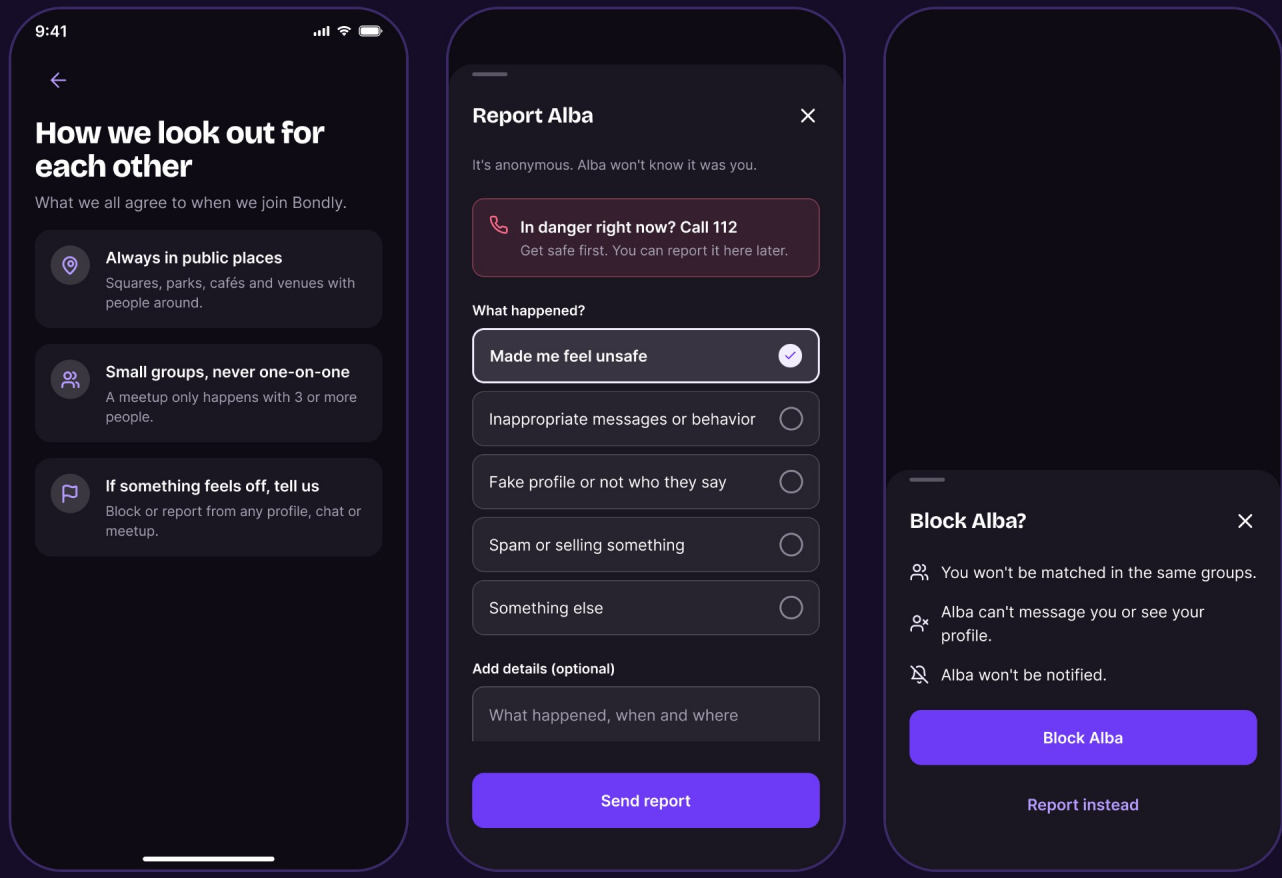
- Empty states point to the next action instead of a dead end.
- Loading keeps the layout in place, so nothing jumps.
- Errors explain what happened and offer a way out.



DESIGN · SAFETY AND TRUST

# Meeting strangers needs trust built in

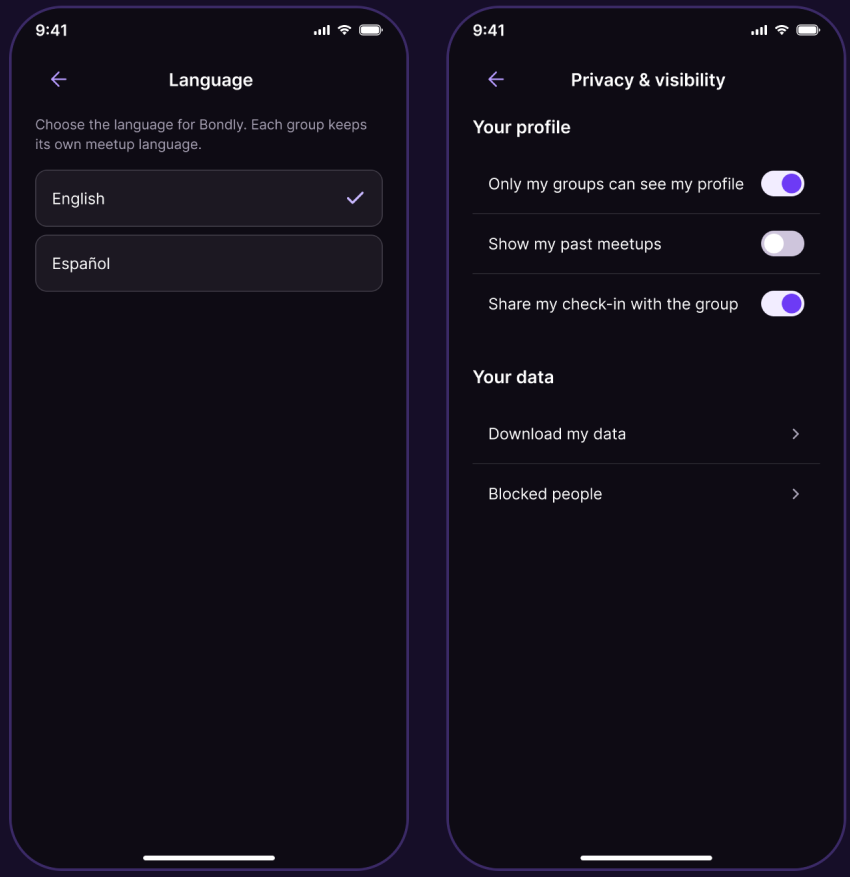
- Clear rules from day one: public places only, and never one-on-one.
- Anonymous reports, with the emergency number shown first.
- Blocking explains exactly what changes, and the other person isn't told.



DESIGN · UNDER THE HOOD

# A prototype that behaves like the app

- Variables hold the state: joining, cancelling or suggesting a meetup updates the screens that show it.
- Fully bilingual: one setting switches every string between English and Spanish, so testers use their own language.
- Permissions in context: location while exploring, notifications after joining a first meetup.
- A documented design system: tokens, type scale, components and usage rules.



VALIDATION · USABILITY TEST, ROUND 1

# 4 of 5 participants completed the journey

## Saying you're running late

**Observed:** the sheet closed with no feedback, so it wasn't clear the group had been told.

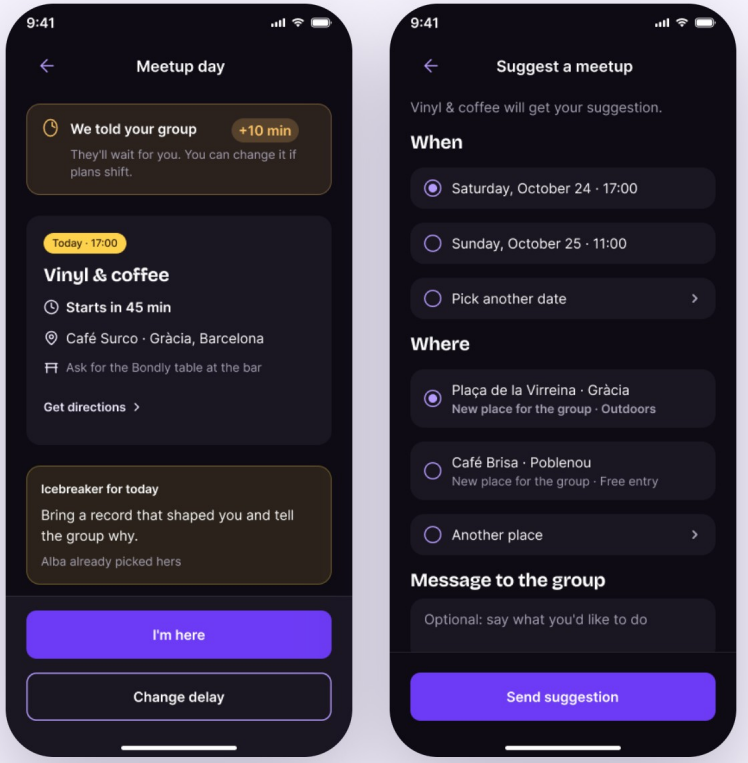
**Fix:** a confirmation with the delay, your status in the arrivals list and a "Change delay" button.

## Suggesting the next meetup

**Observed:** the date and place options didn't respond, so the plan couldn't be changed.

**Fix:** selectable dates and places, and the sent suggestion shows the choice.

**Did not complete:** P_ stopped at [step], because [reason].




5 participants · moderated remote sessions on Google Meet · clickable Figma prototype

REFLECTION · WHAT I LEARNED

# What I'd take into the next project

[icon: Compass]

### Let research move the problem

I started from meeting someone new. The interviews showed the real drop-off is showing up, and then meeting again.

[icon: Cursor]

### Fidelity is part of the test

Both round-1 issues were screens that didn't respond. A dead tap reads as a design flaw, so every path has to work before testing.

[icon: ArrowsClockwise]

### What I'd do differently

[One concrete change to your process, and why]

VALIDATION · WHAT'S NEXT

# Re-test the fixes, then pilot the group rules

## VALIDATION PLAN

**Usability test, round 2:** re-test running late and suggesting a meetup with three new participants.

**Small pilot:** compare sign-ups with real attendance, and track second meetups.

Success criteria defined before the pilot.

## STILL OPEN

Groups of six and the three-person rule.

What "free" means for cafés.

Who welcomes the group on arrival.